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Charting the Evolution: Professionalizing Social Work in Jordan—A Critical Analysis of the Transition from Semi-Profession to Full Professionalization

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Abstract

This paper examines the development process that frames the professionalization of social work in Jordan between 2019 and 2023, situated within the European Union-funded *Support to Social Protection Programme: Helping Deliver Social Inclusion*. Working in collaboration with the Ministry of Social Development (MoSD), the initiative sought to strengthen the professional infrastructure through legislative development, specialist training, and the establishment of accredited university-level curricula to support a coherent, national career pathway for social workers. This paper critically analyses the transition from semi-professional to full professional status, with particular attention to the model used to facilitate ownership by four Jordanian universities and harness and strengthen the practice of social work. It further examines the academic framework underpinning the development of a national Common Core Curriculum for Social Work, drawing on established curriculum theories to guide the negotiated application of global approaches within the Jordanian context, with sensitivity to indigenous knowledge and cultural awareness. Reflections on the strengths and limitations of the development process are informed by stakeholder feedback, current outcomes, and anticipated future developments, with an emphasis on the value of interagency collaboration and networking approaches.

Keywords: social work education; professionalization of social work; curriculum design and development; common core curriculum; inter-university collaboration

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1. Introduction

This paper examines a critical phase in the professionalization of social work in Jordan from 2019 to 2023, situated within a broader history of social work development and shaped by increasingly complex social challenges practitioners face. While earlier initiatives contributed important foundations, this period marked a distinct shift towards formal professional recognition, national coordination, and an agreed national social work curriculum within higher education.

The professionalization efforts discussed were supported through the European Union-funded *Support to Social Protection Programme: Helping Deliver Social Inclusion*, implemented

in partnership with the Ministry of Social Development (MoSD). These efforts encompassed legislative reform and the development of a national, accredited, university-level curriculum designed to structure professional pathways for social workers and strengthen workforce preparedness.

This transformative journey is the outcome of collaborative endeavors involving various stakeholders, such as the Northern Ireland Cooperation Overseas (NI-CO), MoSD, Universities, the Accreditation and Quality Assurance Commission for Higher Education Institutions (AQACHEI), the Jordanian Association of Social Work (JASW), and international partners, all operating under the umbrella of the EU-funded "Support to Social Protection Programme."

The paper begins by foregrounding Jordan's geographical context, followed by an introduction to the history of social work in Jordan and the drivers for the professionalization of social work. Details of the project funding illustrate the role of external European support in developing a Common Core Curriculum, before highlighting several challenges and dilemmas. This background sets the scene for establishing a rich partnership with the four Jordanian universities delivering social work and for applying a curriculum design framework that can guide the development of an agile and flexible curriculum capable of supporting disciplinary coherence while remaining responsive to local teaching praxis and contextual priorities. In the final section, the critical evaluation addresses issues associated with the application of Global North models of social work and their interplay with indigenous knowledge and cultural awareness. This paper advocates an interagency approach and networking among local and international key actors.

2. Geographical Context

Jordan is situated in the heart of the Middle East in western Asia. It is formally the Hashemite Kingdom of Jordan, an Arab nation spanning 89,213 square kilometers (Maaiah and Wouhoush 2020). Jordan shares extensive land boundaries totaling 1635 km with Iraq (181 km), Israel (238 km), Saudi Arabia (744 km), Syria (375 km), and the West Bank (97 km). The country is administratively divided into 12 governorates: Ajlun, Al Aqabah, Al Balqa, Al Karak, Al Mafraq, Amman, At Tafilah, Az Zarqa, Irbid, Jarash, Ma'an, and Madaba (Petrov 2010). Jordan is known for its high standards of safety and security (Maaiah and Wouhoush 2020).

Jordan boasts a population where approximately 98 percent identify as Arabs, while the remaining 2 percent comprises Circassian, Chechen, and Armenian minority groups (Petrov 2010). Arabic serves as the official language, and English is widely understood. Notably, Muslims and Christians have coexisted peacefully in Jordan for decades. Since 1952, Jordan has been a constitutional monarchy with a parliamentary government. The legal code has evolved from historical precedents rooted in Islamic law (sharia), French law during Ottoman rule, and British common law from the mandate period.

Regarding gender and employment dynamics, gender segregation is a defining feature of Arab society, contributing to consistently low rates of female employment and labor force participation in Jordan (Sawalha and Meaton 2012). Women are underrepresented in leadership roles, with only 20 of 130 seats in the Jordanian parliament held by women (Maaiah and Wouhoush 2020).

Challenges persist in pay equity, with women often receiving lower pay than men in similar skill categories (Sawalha and Meaton 2012). Cultural and religious factors play a significant role in shaping gender equality in leadership and employment, though there is limited evidence in the literature. The tribal system, which is deeply rooted in Bedouin culture, shapes Jordan's conservative society, affecting family honor and values. Jordanian

traditions encompass diverse aspects of lifestyle, cuisine, traditional dress codes, and events and festivals, reflecting a rich cultural heritage (Maaiah and Wouhoush 2020).

3. Social Work History in Jordan

Historically, up until the 20th century, family members, tribal leaders, and religious figures served as counselors, healers, and advisors during times of crisis. However, as Jordan faced various socioeconomic challenges in the 20th century, including poverty, unemployment, population growth, and political instability in the Middle East, traditional responses to social needs gave rise to formal contributions from charitable organizations (Al-Makhamreh and Libal 2012). The Department of Social Affairs was established in the 1960s and introduced key legislation to assist the impoverished and young offenders. By the end of the century, the Ministry of Social Development played a prominent role in addressing issues such as disability welfare, employment, and overall development. NGOs like the Queen Alia Fund were also established during these years.

Between 2009 and 2019, the main landmark in developing social work practice was Jordan's refugee response, which evolved from primarily emergency-based interventions to more structured, resilience- and development-oriented frameworks. While support was mobilized in response to earlier displacement waves and significantly intensified after the Syrian crisis in 2011, the scale and protracted nature of displacement quickly exceeded national service capacity, creating persistent gaps in access and quality.

From 2011 to 2013, the response was largely humanitarian and internationally led. However, as displacement became protracted, the Government of Jordan institutionalized its approach. The launch of the Jordan Response Plan (JRP) in 2014 marked a turning point by formalizing a humanitarian–development nexus and aligning international assistance with national priorities (Global Compact on Refugees 2024). Between 2014 and 2019, this shift was reinforced through national frameworks such as the National Employment Plan (2011–2020) and the National Social Protection Strategy (2019–2025), which emphasized resilience, equitable access to services, and alignment with the Sustainable Development Goals.

During this period, localization also gained momentum. Although localization commitments were globally endorsed earlier, implementation in Jordan progressed gradually, with national actors increasingly advocating for stronger local leadership (Humanitarian Partners Forum 2021). The sustained pressure on infrastructure and public systems between 2014 and 2019 further underscored the need to strengthen national institutions and local civil society capacity.

These shifts significantly expanded the scope of social work practice across macro-, meso-, and micro-levels (Naseh and Potocky 2019). Social workers contributed to policy advocacy and planning, program design and coordination, and direct case management (Almakhamreh et al. 2022). Urban displacement dynamics intensified psychosocial and social cohesion challenges, leading to increased recruitment of social workers to implement evidence-based mental health and psychosocial interventions (Sijbrandij et al. 2017). Their frontline role in needs identification and community recovery became central to the national response (Global Social Service Workforce Alliance 2022).

Overall, the 2009–2019 period reflects a clear transition toward integrated, nationally framed resilience planning, which substantially increased the demand for qualified social workers within the humanitarian–development nexus.

The documented history of formalized social work in Jordan is relatively brief (Cocks et al. 2009). The initiative to professionalize social work in Jordan gained momentum in 2008, spearheaded by social work academics who collaborated with the British Council. They organized a conference to collectively recognize social work as a profession and to

inaugurate the Association of Social Work. This marked a pivotal step towards organizing and regulating the professional practice of social work in Jordan (Sullivan et al. 2010).

Despite these developments, social work as a profession faced delays in formal education. The delivery of professional social work remained largely unorganized, controlled by various government bodies, NGOs, and other agencies rather than a unified professional system (Al-Makhamreh and Libal 2012). In contrast to Egypt, where social work education dates back to 1935 with the adoption of an American model, Jordan established its first formal training program in 1965, offering a two-year diploma for high school graduates. At that time, individuals wishing to obtain university degrees in social work typically pursued their studies outside Jordan, often in non-Arab states (Albrithen 2012). Al Balqa Applied University took charge of the diploma program in 1998, which was later replaced by an undergraduate degree in social work in 2006. The University of Jordan introduced a non-thesis graduate degree in 1999, providing advanced training in various practice areas. Recently, the German Jordanian University in 2018 established a Social Work Master's program in Migration and Refugees and two professional diplomas on Clinical Mental Health and Social Work Migration and Refugees.

Notwithstanding progress in elevating educational standards, societal pressures persist for a social work community with limited formal training. Challenges include the strain on the country's infrastructure from the large number of Iraqi refugees (Care Jordan 2023). However, the existing workforce often lacks sufficient knowledge and skills to effectively address these needs. The recurring theme identified in the literature is the absence of an agreed framework of locally grounded social work knowledge and competencies in Jordan (Al-Makhamreh and Libal 2012). In practice, social workers frequently base their decision-making on individual, cultural, and religious beliefs; professional experience; and, in some cases, on Global North theories and methods that may or may not be culturally relevant to the local context (Al-Makhamreh and Libal 2012; Sullivan et al. 2010). Recognizing the need for a plan for social work's future, influential practitioners, educators, and government representatives subsequently reviewed the current workforce and educational developments in social work education (Al-Makhamreh and Libal 2012).

In 2008, they developed a strategy to establish a professional social work association, supported by Queen Rania, the Jordanian government, and the British Council. The first association was formed but later declined due to members' commitments. It was reestablished in 2016 under the Ministry of Interior as the Jordanian Association for Social Work (AlMakhamreh et al. 2025). Although initially aimed at advancing professional identity, regulation, and advocacy, the association again became inactive within a few years, primarily due to internal issues such as limited income, low member participation, competing responsibilities, and a lack of a supportive regulatory framework.

The phrase "diminished by the same professionals who established it" reflects the reality that many founding members were unable to sustain active involvement due to workload pressures, a lack of institutional incentives, and unclear professional recognition. As a result, leadership and organizational continuity could not be maintained, leading to the association's eventual inactivity. It could be argued that Queen Rania's initiatives in 2008 represented a renewed push toward professionalization, particularly through advocacy for education reform, capacity building, and social development. Between 2008 and 2019, progress toward professionalization continued in a fragmented and uneven manner. During this period, efforts were primarily driven by academic institutions, individual practitioners, and international or regional partnerships rather than a centralized professional body. These included curriculum development initiatives, specialized training programs, and increased engagement with international social work standards; however, the absence of

a sustained national association limited the consolidation of these efforts into a unified professional framework.

Furthermore, the refugee population in Jordan prompted social workers and humanitarian actors to actively respond to the demographic challenge. This active engagement is evident in the implementation of numerous social protection and humanitarian assistance programs by NGOs and social workers to address the unique needs of refugees in the region. It is crucial to highlight that this situation places a critical demand on the role of social workers to effectively address emerging challenges (Al Husseini 2023).

4. Drivers for the Professionalization of Social Work in Jordan

The heightened demand for social services in a community can be directly attributed to the region's instability and complexity. The substantial influx of Syrian refugees over the past decade, coupled with an increasing number of Iraqi, Somali, and Sudanese refugees, has resulted in a growing population of vulnerable individuals grappling with restricted access to fundamental rights and essential services such as healthcare, food, shelter, and education (Care Jordan 2023). This predicament is particularly pronounced in communities where most refugees have settled, placing significant strain on local resources, employment opportunities, and access to services (Care Jordan 2023). According to the Vulnerability Assessment Framework (VAF) Model, an alarming 86% of Syrian refugee individuals are classified as "highly or severely vulnerable," as reported by the UNHCR (2022).

In 2022, Syrian refugees residing outside of camp settings in Jordan encountered escalating barriers to basic services, with 88% of households grappling with debt and financial hardships and 42% relying on cash assistance for survival (Care Jordan 2023). Furthermore, educational challenges were evident, with 32% of Syrian boys and 30% of girls reporting non-attendance in school (Care Jordan 2023).

The diverse refugee populations in Jordan, comprising Syrian families alongside Iraqis, Sudanese, Somalis, and others, confront a myriad of challenges that heighten their susceptibility to legal conflicts. Legal issues for Syrian refugees and impoverished households are intricate, encompassing factors such as trauma, negative coping mechanisms within families and extended families, specific gender-related vulnerabilities affecting female-headed households, tensions between refugee and host communities, instances of discrimination and violence, and de facto exclusion from the labor market (Care Jordan 2023; UNHCR 2024).

Refugee crises have led to an increase in social work service projects. However, the sudden surge in demand for social workers in Jordan has led to challenges, including the presence of unqualified social workers, many of whom hold degrees in other specialties. Additionally, the absence of legislation and policies governing and monitoring the social work field, along with the lack of a licensing requirement, further exacerbates the issues at hand. These concerns were duly acknowledged and addressed in the 2019 National Social Protection Strategy. The 2019 National Social Protection Strategy explicitly recognizes the imperative to professionalize social work as an integral part of Jordan's social protection system. The strategy outlines key objectives, including updating the legislative framework governing the Ministry of Social Development, particularly Article 13 of Law No. 14 of 1956, to align the Ministry's mandate with its contemporary roles and priorities. This entails incorporating aspects such as case management and integration into family and community dynamics. Moreover, the strategy calls for legislation to formalize and professionalize social workers' roles in the evolving social landscape.

The renewed push toward professionalization in Jordan was driven not only by the increasing number of refugees but also by the growing complexity of social problems, including emerging mental health needs, child protection concerns, and heightened vulnerability among multiple population groups. These challenges exposed significant gaps in

professional skills, tools, and evidence-based interventions required to respond effectively. During this period, many individuals working in social service roles did not hold degrees in social work and relied instead on personal experience and informal, trial-and-error approaches. Although various projects, trainings, and workshops were implemented between 2008 and 2019, these efforts were fragmented and insufficient to address systemic capacity gaps. The combination of escalating and increasingly complex social needs, limited professional regulation, and inconsistent educational preparation ultimately led to the decision to engage international consultants to support the reorganization and strengthening of social work education and professional standards.

5. European Union Funding, 2019–2023

Since 2000, Jordan has seen a notable shift in academic focus, particularly in the professionalization of social work. A significant initiative in this regard was the "Support to Social Protection Program: Helping Deliver Social Inclusion," funded by the European Union from 2019 to 2023. Within this program, a key objective was to advance the professionalization of social work in collaboration with the MoSD. These concerted efforts included drafting legislation, providing specialized training, and establishing accredited university-level curricula to structure the career pathway for social workers. This transformative journey was the outcome of collaborative endeavors involving various stakeholders, such as the Northern Ireland Cooperation Overseas (NI-CO), MoSD, universities, the Accreditation and Quality Assurance Commission for Higher Education Institutions (AQACHEI), the Jordanian Association of Social Work (JASW), and international partners, all operating under the umbrella of the EU-funded "Support to Social Protection Program" (AlMakhamreh et al. 2025).

In 2019, NI-CO was given responsibility for the professionalization of social work and identified university social work education as a core driver that would significantly improve workforce quality. It was agreed that developing a Common Core Curriculum was essential to the work. There were three key objectives to be addressed:

1. Identification of the key elements of social work university education.
2. Standardization of social work education across universities offering social work education.
3. An agreed and validated process of curriculum development.

At the outset, embarking on a journey to develop a Common Core Curriculum for Social Work in Jordan presented both challenging and visionary prospects, given the limited history of collaboration among academic institutions. The roots of Social Work in Jordan lie in legislation enacted in 1956 (Ministry of Social Development 1956), so the commitment to addressing social issues facing the Jordanian nation is long-standing. However, respective university courses for social work addressed professional education in distinctive ways, with a strong emphasis on theoretical and research perspectives. An emerging focus on practice education was not a consistent theme within some professional education.

The female international support team comprised two complementary roles: a senior curriculum specialist with expertise in facilitating evidence-informed, structured curriculum design processes, and a Professor of Social Work who contributed subject-specific expertise and experience in leading collaborative partnerships in social work education. Together, their roles were intentionally differentiated: curriculum leadership focused on design methodology and process, and disciplinary leadership contributed professional and pedagogical insight, while substantive curriculum decisions remained locally led. The gender composition of the academic participants from the four Jordanian universities comprised ten female and three male staff members participating in the curriculum development workshops. The role, experience, and professional disposition of the international experts commissioned to develop the Common Core Curriculum were integral to the successful establishment of a coherent and contextually relevant framework. Although the

European Union employed the term expert, all participants were selected on the basis of their demonstrable commitment to a shared, collaborative responsibility for advancing the professionalization of social work in Jordan. This emphasis on collective ownership and mutual accountability was a defining feature of the project's methodology.

A distinctive strength of the contributors from Northern Ireland was their lived experience of professionalizing social work within a society emerging from decades of conflict and trauma during the period known as the Troubles. Their professional trajectories equipped them with an acute awareness of the importance of cultural sensitivity, reflective listening, contextual understanding, and partnership-based practice—principles that align closely with contemporary international standards in social work education and capacity-building. MacDermott (2024) provides a comprehensive account of the historical evolution of social work and social work education in Northern Ireland, offering valuable insights into how this background informed and enriched the professionalization of social work in a traumatized, developing society.

6. Challenges and Dilemmas in Developing a Common Core Curriculum with a Global Context of Social Work

Preparatory work for the project raised fundamental questions about how a Global North model of social work practice could be integrated with local histories, cultural practices, and epistemologies that challenged dominant narratives. The socio-political context of Northern Ireland, with its longstanding sectarian divide and well-recognized legacy of generalized trauma, was directly the result of a deep-seated colonial past. Social work education in this context had navigated a complex landscape of delivery of social work services to marginalized communities for over 50 years, addressing endemic mental health problems of its population (Campbell and McCrystal 2005), alongside emerging demands from migrant populations who were experiencing racism and marginalization (Duffy et al. 2019; Campbell et al. 2021). Although colonialism was a common element for consideration, the challenges extended primarily to pedagogical processes and student learning. Crisp (2024) highlights the importance of two key factors that need to be addressed: (1) understanding the importance of connectedness as a mechanism for decolonizing the curriculum and (2) a crosspollination of ideas, which involves renegotiation between Global North and Global South knowledge systems and indigenous values and knowledge.

Saxton (2026) addresses the tensions in the uncritical adoption of international social work standards, arguing that they may restrict the development of indigenous theories and practices. Foregrounding her work in Fijian culture, she contends that the emergence of local social work practices reflects the dichotomy between Global North individualized practices and case management, versus "culturally informed practice" on the other hand. Furthermore, it offers opportunities for reflective practice to understand how global social work influences provide a scaffold for incorporating indigenous models. One criticism leveled at the development of the Common Core Curriculum in Jordan is that it is limited by a Global North model of social work. However, the detailed exposition of the process belies the common ground forged with the academic colleagues in Jordan, which was underpinned by mutual respect for diversity alongside carefully crafted opportunities to explore each other's cultural contexts. Social issues such as poverty, migration, economic inequalities, and a recognition of societies framed by trauma and social deprivation formed the common ground. Recognition of community realities was explored through exercises that fostered shared perspectives. At the outset, the divergent perspectives provided a basis for exploration, as academic colleagues were already teaching students about social work values, though there was variability in practice education experiences. Saxton (2026) argues that this very praxis of sharing elucidates the development of a common ground.

"...International discussions on social work should clearly articulate its nature and purpose to support localized and indigenous understandings of the profession."

Martin et al. (2023) conducted a scoping review of the benefits of integrating design thinking into social work education, articulating the contributions of this process to social justice and social change by emphasizing knowledge exchange and innovation. Examples of how this was achieved are explored in the next section.

7. Developing a Common Core Curriculum

7.1. What Is a Common Core Curriculum for Social Work?

A Common Core Curriculum can be described as a systematic organization of taught courses and learning in practice, which form the building blocks of professional training across each semester and each year of a social work program. Combining academic subjects with opportunities to undertake direct practice helps prospective students understand theoretical perspectives and apply them to their experience working with individuals, families, groups, and communities.

In outlining the complex history of global social work, Chowa et al. (2025) identify the legacy of colonialism in the emergence of social work, while acknowledging the influence of indigenous developments that preceded Global North colonialism. Their seminal work examines how power dynamics have set the backdrop to these developments. Through a careful examination of the paradigms, such as neoliberalism, human development theory, and Sen's emphasis on capabilities approach, they contend that two perspectives predominate with the Global North focus on "...universalizing top down interventions for the individual" by comparison to a Global South "person in environment approach" based on a sociological perspective (Chowa et al. 2025, p. 35). Drawing on the International Federation of Social Work definition of social work, the authors advocate that "social work must be operationally different according to context because this will ensure that social workers will understand the reciprocity between people, and their environments..." (Chowa et al. 2025, p. 41).

Al-Krenawi (2025), writing from an Arab–Islamic perspective, acknowledges the longstanding influence of Global North social work models, linking this to colonialist attempts, which have consistently failed to embrace indigenous knowledge. Contending that efforts to incorporate global models of social work must also have foundations in Islamic principles and practices, the author articulates the process of how this can be achieved. In addressing some details on how Islamic beliefs and the Pillars of Islam can be realized in social work practice, the author defines how an Islamic perspective emerged from a recognition of the need to develop a culturally sensitive curriculum and teaching materials to reflect this. Despite the tensions in the interface between Global North models of social work and the development of indigenous integration, the similarities between Global North ethical values and Islamic teachings suggest greater cohesion. He found that the two sets of values align on the parameters of competence, social justice, and the importance of human relationships and human dignity (Al-Krenawi, 2025). Several examples are explored to illustrate the relevance of this interface, e.g., the role of a medical social worker whose role in working with service recipients would have to take account of traditional Islamic preferences for the gender of the social worker, as well as the service recipients' views regarding personal contact or eye contact and presence of a trusted family member during the interview (Al-Krenawi, 2025). Earlier work by Al-Krenawi and Graham (1999) also points out the relevance of systematic assessment processes, underpinned by professional supervision and ethics for social workers whose practice embraces Quranic healing. Finally, despite critiques of Global North approaches, Al-Krenawi and Graham (1999) express optimism about the development of "local" social

work, which fuses the best of "both worlds", that of Islamic ways of knowing and that of "global knowledge". Notwithstanding this, the prospect needs to incorporate two further elements, critical self-reflection and power analysis, to acknowledge that the role of privilege is addressed. Albrithen (2023) explored similar themes to examine the congruence between social work values and Islam by analyzing, in detail, the concept of social justice, which underpins equality, human rights, and supports anti-oppressive practice (p. 180). The author concluded that the ongoing Global North influences are tempered by a growing resurgence in Islamic practices, which are aligned with local cultures.

Thus, the emerging picture suggests areas of confluence where unique indigenous practices can become more influential. However, core tension still exists. Despite recognition of progress achieved in Jordan's efforts to develop the social work workforce through the development of a state-approved social work curriculum, the current uncertainty about the definitions and requirements of social work, alongside shortages of social workers, suggests more fundamental problems with the infrastructure and systemic challenges. The Arab Region Hub for Social Protection (2025) references the need for a "needs-led, person-centered approach" to underscore the global perspective on social work services based on assessment of need and relationship-based practice. Such factors influenced the development of the Common Core Curriculum that emerged from the collaborative processes with the four universities.

The revision of the older Code of Ethics was necessary due to the significant transformation of social work practice, particularly within humanitarian and displacement contexts. Social workers now operate in increasingly complex environments characterized by protracted crises, urban refugee settings, and heightened mental health and psychosocial needs (Protection Cluster et al. 2021). These evolving realities introduce ethical challenges—such as culturally responsive practice, gender sensitivity, safeguarding, confidentiality in emergency settings, and equitable service provision—that were not comprehensively addressed in earlier versions of the Code. Moreover, social workers' roles have expanded beyond individual case management to include community-based interventions, participatory approaches, policy advocacy, and multi-sectoral coordination. The integration of mental health and psychosocial support into emergency response frameworks, alongside the emphasis on "do no harm" principles and structure.

Therefore, the revision was essential to ensure that the Code reflects contemporary humanitarian practice, strengthens accountability, and provides practical ethical direction aligned with current professional responsibilities (Almakhamreh et al. 2022; Global Social Service Workforce Alliance 2022).

7.2. What Are the Benefits of a Common Core Curriculum for Social Work?

Key benefits include strengthening national coherence through standardized foundational learning, assuring comparable competence levels across institutions, and supporting professional recognition of qualifications across Jordan. Within the CCC, a defined and limited number of shared courses were agreed upon nationally, while individual universities retained the autonomy to include additional optional courses and contextual enhancements aligned to their institutional strengths and regional priorities.

From a learning-in-practice perspective, students develop a clear understanding of their statutory role as social workers, demonstrate competence in interprofessional and organizational contexts, and apply the social work process effectively—including relationship-building with service users, assessment and report writing, ethical decision-making, and professional accountability through supervision and reflective practice.

Collectively, these benefits position the CCC as both a quality assurance mechanism and a professional formation framework, strengthening workforce readiness while preserving institutional flexibility and contextual relevance.

7.3. What Are the Disadvantages of a Common Core Curriculum?

Some concerns about developing a Common Core Curriculum relate to the potential loss of individuality and expertise at individual Universities. These can be very real concerns when academic institutions have a long-established history of delivering social work education. Similarly, there may be concerns about diluting the reputation and importance of particular institutions, especially if an academic institution has an established track record of research and publication. In such circumstances, there may be perceptions of hierarchy or prestige in the delivery of social work education. Equally, legitimate concerns may arise about maintaining minimum standards when social work education is delivered across multiple institutions, with different staff groups, different management structures, and operational practices.

At the heart of these concerns lie fears about implementation of change, fears about professional identity, and natural resistance to new ideas and ways of working. The important lesson is that such concerns can be anticipated, negotiated, and are part of the engagement process, and they should not be viewed as obstacles to developing and implementing a Common Core Curriculum. The following section outlines the process used to develop the CCC in Jordan.

8. Foundation for an Inter-University Partnership

The development of a Common Core Curriculum for Jordan was based on the EU-Funded Social Protection Programme, Component 5 Mission, which stated: *"Social Work curricula and guidelines of Universities are accredited by the quality assurance and accreditation institutions of Higher Education" (NI-CO 2023)*.

Expected results of this mission included the "development of a cross-faculty curriculum and programs with universities. . . on specialization in social work, based on the national standards of accreditation".

In this pursuit, academics from four universities with social work programs in Jordan, Al Balqa Applied University, University of Jordan, German Jordanian University, and Yarmouk University, were identified for an inter-university partnership. The national Common Core Curriculum was developed to establish a shared foundational framework for social work education across Jordanian universities while allowing for institutional-level flexibility. Its primary goals were to ensure consistency in professional competencies, promote ethical and culturally responsive practice, and align social work education with national priorities and emerging social needs. The Common Core was not intended to rigidly standardize content but to provide a cohesive foundation upon which universities could build context-specific adaptations.

Common Core courses were jointly designed through a collaborative process that included local academics from partner universities, consultants, and strategic stakeholders. Beyond brief course descriptions, each course was guided by clearly defined objectives and learning outcomes that emphasized applying social work ethics, community-based practice, and culturally grounded interventions. Course content, learning activities, and assessment methods were collectively reviewed to ensure relevance to Jordanian social, cultural, and institutional contexts. Local perspectives were addressed by incorporating case studies from local practice settings, engaging local practitioners in curriculum development and delivery, and contextualizing theoretical content within national policy frameworks, family structures, and community systems. While the Common Core provided a shared

academic foundation, each university retained autonomy to adapt course delivery, readings further, and applied components in response to regional needs, institutional capacity, and student populations.

The foundations for national collaborative engagement were achieved through preparatory consultations with senior leaders within the respective institutions, their senior social work academics, and senior staff from the AQACHEI. Relationship building and the development of trust and respect were established as cornerstones of achieving the Project's Mission through a Network that facilitates the co-creation of a National Social Work Common Core Curriculum (CCC) for Jordan.

This collaborative initiative sought to strengthen national academic standards for social work in Jordan by articulating a shared, transparent profile of the discipline and clarifying the intended graduate capabilities in terms of what social work graduates should know, be able to do, and embody upon completion of their degree program (Barnett and Coate 2005). This framing aligns with subsequent curriculum scholarship that emphasizes learning as professional formation and becoming, particularly within complex and uncertain practice contexts (Barnett 2009), and resonates with global competency-based approaches that integrate knowledge, skills, and values to prepare graduates for complex societal challenges (OECD 2019). Rather than prescribing content, the initiative prioritized a co-design and co-development approach, engaging academic staff and national stakeholders in structured design-thinking activities (Pressman 2018) informed by the curriculum frameworks. Such an approach reflects scholarship that positions the curriculum as relational, collaborative, and purpose-driven rather than as a fixed body of knowledge (Lindén et al. 2017; Fung 2017).

To operationalize these principles, an inter-university partnership was established among four Jordanian universities (Al-Balqa Applied University, University of Jordan, German Jordanian University, and Yarmouk University), along with the Ministry of Social Development and the national accreditation body (AQACHEI). Preparatory consultations secured institutional commitment, clarified governance arrangements, and embedded trust, transparency and shared responsibility as guiding principles.

Over a nine-month period, the Common Core Curriculum (CCC) was developed through three co-facilitated, residential, co-creation workshops (the workshops were held in a hotel at the Dead Sea). The approach was guided by a design thinking methodology and grounded in the Integrated Curriculum Design Framework (Murphy and Curran 2020). This structured yet iterative process enabled the development of an agile curriculum that ensured disciplinary coherence while remaining responsive to local teaching praxis and contextual priorities. In articulating the graduate profile and shared course constructs, the partnership also drew upon international reference points for social work education, including the "IASSW Global Standards for Social Work Education and Training" (IASSW and IFSW 2020) while contextualizing these within Jordanian policy frameworks and practice realities.

The first residential established the inter-university leadership network and facilitated structured practice exchange. Participants collaboratively agreed on a shared curriculum philosophy, articulated the intended graduate profile (knowledge, skills, and professional values), defined the program's aim, and reached consensus on four foundational courses forming the CCC.

In the second phase of the residential workshop, these constructs were documented in a formal Program Handbook and aligned with course descriptions. Course development leads were officially appointed, and each university was designated to oversee one of the four courses. An inter-institutional design team, comprising representatives from all four universities, was formed for each course. This setup promoted shared ownership and collaboration across institutions for every course, while also enhancing sustainability

by allowing each university to gain a comprehensive understanding of all four courses for effective local implementation. These teams collaboratively refined and standardized course descriptors while ensuring contextual sensitivity.

The third residential session focused on stakeholder consultation, refinement, and preparation for implementation. Design teams were expanded to include the AQACHEI, the Ministry, and service-provider stakeholders to align with national accreditation standards and workforce needs. Course descriptors were refined through repeated reviews and consultations with accreditation officials and practice settings, such as fieldwork offices. This process ensured the curriculum was nationally coherent and rooted in Jordanian policy, community systems, and service realities.

The co-design process was guided by organized pre-work, shared templates, course planning tools, and multiple rounds of feedback. While creating shared national standards, the CCC was purposely designed with limited flexibility, allowing universities to adapt delivery methods, applied learning activities, and assessment strategies to regional needs and institutional strengths. Overall, these steps led to a comprehensive, locally managed curriculum that facilitates the systematic evaluation of social work knowledge, skills, and professional values across different institutions.

To ensure sustainability beyond the project and embed curriculum reform within national structures, a National Committee for University Social Work Education was established in 2023. It includes representatives from Jordanian universities, the Accreditation and Quality Assurance Commission for Higher Education Institutions (AQACHEI), and the MoSD, serving as a formal mechanism for inter-university coordination and shared decision-making. The Committee oversees the ongoing development and enhancement of a Common Core Curriculum, supports alignment with accreditation standards, and supervises program approvals through the AQACHEI. It aims to enhance local ownership of curriculum decisions and sustain collaboration after external support ends.

9. Achieving National Accreditation of the Common Core Curriculum for Social Work

The purpose of the Common Core Curriculum (CCC) was to ensure that Jordanian social work graduates who had completed a university social work program had the *core* knowledge, skills, and experience required to practice social work in Jordan. The main goals of the CCC included:

- Being familiar with basic concepts of the social work profession (knowledge/understanding/application);
- Identifying the challenges experienced in Jordanian society (individuals/groups/society/institutions);
- Being aware of the role of the social worker (expert/enabler/practitioner/advocate;
- Mastering verbal and non-verbal communication skills;
- Applying and practicing the principles and ethics of the social work profession in dealing with individuals, groups, and society;
- Applying scientific research using social theories in the field of evidence-based practice.

10. The Common Core Curriculum Courses

The consensus of the National Committee for University Social Work Education on the formulation of the Common Core Curriculum comprised the following four courses to be implemented across all social work programs in Jordan.

10.1. Ethics and Values

This course challenges students to explore the ethics and values relevant to social work and the interrelationship between their personal and professional values.

10.2. Communication Skills in Social Work

This course develops students' understanding of and skills in interpersonal communication to enable effective communication in social work and human services.

10.3. Integrated Practice

This course prepares students to acquire unique skills in the practice of assessment and intervention, extending to the individual, group, community, and social policy levels. Focusing on building students' capacities is important.

10.4. Practice Education

This course provides placements across a range of settings where social services are practiced, enabling students to develop their role as social workers and apply the profession's principles, ethics, and skills with full commitment.

The inter-university partnership culminated in the completion and submission of a nationally agreed-upon foundation for social work higher education to the Accreditation and Quality Assurance Commission for Higher Education Institutions (AQACHEI), which officially sanctioned the Common Core Curriculum in May 2023. A significant milestone in the professionalization of social work in Jordan occurred with the development and endorsement of the Social Work Law by the Ministry of Social Development (MoSD) on 14 May 2023. Aligned with Jordan's higher education strategy, the Ministry of Higher Education and Scientific Research (MoHE 2020) advocates for the integration of theory and practice alongside cultural exchange programs between Global North and Global South universities.

The ongoing objective of the National Committee for University Social Work Education continues to refine curriculum requirements, ensuring alignment with the expectations of key stakeholders and employers.

Local efforts to professionalize social work continue to progress. The voluntary national team for professionalizing social work in Jordan conducts workshops at the Ministry of Social Development headquarters, focusing on enhancing the professional competence of the social work force and social care.

Concurrently, there is active development towards the formation of an association of social workers. In 2023, there was a concerted effort to further professionalize social work through strategic alliances among the Ministry of Social Development and multiple universities.

11. Charting the Progress of Approval and Implementation

The development and implementation of a national social work curriculum in Jordan have been a landmark initiative, grounded in strong collaboration among local academic institutions, policymakers, practitioners, and international partners, including Northern Ireland Cooperation Overseas (NI-CO), particularly colleagues from Northern Ireland. This partnership, built on mutual respect and equal engagement, especially with NI-CO, has significantly advanced not only the development of the core curriculum but also the professionalisation of social work education and policy integration in Jordan (AlMakhamreh et al. 2025).

It is worth mentioning that the transition from tokenistic consultation to meaningful action occurred when feedback from local practitioners and community institutions representatives was formally incorporated into curriculum design and institutional policy.

This turning point was marked by the establishment of a local advisory committee with decision-making authority, comprising academics, professionals, and policymakers; the revision of course content to include locally grounded case studies; and the introduction of assessment criteria that evaluated students' ability to apply social work ethics in cultural and collective contexts. These changes signaled a shift from consultation as a symbolic exercise to consultation as a driver of implementation. The approval process was nationally led and characterized by sustained engagement with all relevant stakeholders, including policymakers, the AQACHEI, the Ministry of Social Development, legal advisors, and universities offering social work programs. From the outset, there was consensus on the need to reform the curriculum to better align with national and international labor market demands and to enhance the professional identity of social workers on the ground, particularly frontline practitioners.

Central to this process were multiple joint workshops that brought together Jordanian and Northern Irish academics and professionals. These efforts culminated in three major residential workshops held on 6 August 2022; 13–15 October 2022; and 23–25 February 2023. These sessions adopted a participatory and inclusive approach, emphasizing the value of co-design, local leadership, and contextualized learning. Individual meetings with each university further ensured institutional buy-in and contextual adaptation of the proposed curriculum.

To ensure relevance and consistency, universities collaboratively identified core courses for their programs, engaging in active discussions to contextualize content and avoid unnecessary duplication. The collective agreement between universities and the AQACHEI reaffirmed the centrality of local academic leadership in curriculum development. The workshops, supported by the Jordanian Association of Social Work, Northern Ireland partners, and the accreditation body, laid a strong foundation for consensus-building and sustainability.

The move from "tokenistic" consultation to "action" had a genuine impact on co-creation and marked a turning point in the process. This shift recognized the need to base curriculum design not solely on academic experience but on expertise responsive to societal needs, labor market realities, and the evolving role of social work. The urgency of developing a core national curriculum, supported by academic leadership from all universities, became clear. In response, the AQACHEI convened a formal meeting to initiate the national curriculum approval process.

On 7 November 2022, the AQACHEI mandated the formation of a national committee of experts from Jordanian universities. The committee was tasked with reviewing the knowledge domains and learning outcomes of the Bachelor of Social Work program to ensure alignment with market requirements and practical training standards. After several months of intensive work, the committee submitted its recommendations. On 11 January 2023, the AQACHEI's council issued Decision No. (1/2/94), approving the revised knowledge domains for the bachelor's program. The curriculum was then officially circulated to university presidents and quality assurance units for implementation.

The approved curriculum was comprehensive, identifying essential knowledge areas, such as intervention and communication skills, individual and group work, community practice, and specialized fields, including work with refugees, children and families, and older adults. It also incorporated vital policy areas, including social planning and institutional management, as well as research methodologies and digital analysis. Each domain was linked to specific, measurable, intended learning outcomes, providing a clear structure for institutions to follow.

The finalized core curriculum manual was distributed nationwide with full endorsement from the Ministry of Social Development and the Ministry of Higher Education.

This marked a significant institutional and policy shift, clearly defining what constitutes standardized social work education in Jordan and underscoring a shared national vision for the profession.

This process highlighted how structured collaboration, grounded in both local and global expertise, can generate not only ideas but also implementable outcomes deeply rooted in the local context. The result was a curriculum that articulated the diverse realities of social work in Jordan while ensuring alignment with international educational standards.

On 28 December 2023, a second national committee was established to develop standards for the knowledge, skills, and competencies required to "nationalize" the Bachelor of Social Work program. Nationalization refers to formally aligning the program with labor market demands and ensuring that all intended learning outcomes are directly connected to employability in the Jordanian, regional, and international contexts. These efforts were formally endorsed in a strategic session held on 24 November 2024.

As of 7 January 2025, the revised curriculum is fully integrated and operational across all social work programs in Jordan, serving as a national standard. The AQACHEI has confirmed that social work programs must adhere to this core curriculum and its associated learning outcomes to obtain or renew accreditation. In this context, the AQACHEI reconvened the workshop participants, now recognized as national curriculum leaders, to oversee the implementation phase and ensure alignment between teaching practices and the labor market.

This collective effort has produced a national curriculum that is both robust and comprehensive, and that reflects Jordan's social realities. It sets a precedent for meaningful academic reform through inclusive, evidence-based collaboration.

12. Reflections on the Professionalization of Social Work Journey in Jordan

Throughout this journey, one of the key aspects has been the consistent advocacy for evidence-based approaches rooted in local realities. Jordan's experience has shown that academic institutions play a critical role in elevating social work by fostering collaboration—whether through joint research, teaching projects, or policy engagement. In this context, academics from four universities worked closely with the Ministry of Social Development and international partners, particularly from the European Union, to support the reform and formal recognition of social work as a professional discipline (Al-Saideh et al. 2024).

The inter-university network and curriculum design thinking facilitation approach were recognized by senior stakeholders as a credible model for future cross-institutional curriculum development, with the accreditation authority noting the process as an exemplar for collaborative work across professions.

Utilizing key representatives from each academic institution to serve as team leaders combined their strengths as insiders—sharing the same language, social norms, and institutional frameworks—while also facilitating communication and building trust among peers, who had long championed the localization of social work practice and policy. In addition, the benefits of a shared history of delivering social work education and cooperation on professional matters, such as organizing Jordan's first national social work conference and contributing to the establishment of the country's formal social work infrastructure, cemented the process. These milestones, underpinned by years of community engagement and policy work, positioned the team leaders to act as cultural and professional liaisons during the collaboration with Northern Ireland Cooperation Overseas (NI-CO) and the policymakers (AQACHEI). In this role, they can help to ensure mutual trust, bridge understanding between Jordanian colleagues and international counterparts, and foster respect and a shared purpose.

However, one of the primary challenges that surfaced during the curriculum development process was the implicit tension between preserving indigenous knowledge and adapting international models. While social work as a discipline shares global principles, its practice is deeply embedded in a cultural context. Concerns were raised about the potential loss of local identity within curriculum frameworks shaped by international standards. However, the international team's expertise and sensitivity to the Jordanian sociocultural environment were essential. At times, we needed to negotiate and contextualize global concepts to ensure they were relevant to our students and communities (Al-Saideh et al. 2024).

Despite these challenges, collaboration within and across Jordanian universities remained strong. There was no evident conflict between colleagues within the same institution or among different universities. On the contrary, when the international team demonstrated a shared goal of developing a unified, high-quality social work curriculum, it strengthened the collective resolve. Our engagements were grounded in mutual respect, recognition of diverse academic experiences, and a shared belief in the value of social work education. The collaborative atmosphere and the need to respond to emerging needs in Jordan, for example, the refugee crisis and the COVID-19 virus, facilitated the respectful exchange of knowledge and pedagogical approaches, with each institution contributing unique perspectives and strengths (Al-Saideh et al. 2024).

13. Lessons Learned from the Process

Transparency, inclusivity, and participatory decision-making emerged as key drivers of the project's success. A national coordinator, who played a central role in navigating both the approval process and the practical implementation of the curriculum, led efforts to document the development process and proposed that module coordinators submit reflective pieces outlining their experiences. These reflections captured lessons learned, highlighted effective strategies, and acknowledged the complexities of working within diverse academic teams. Importantly, they provided insight into how pedagogical diversity could be reconciled through shared values and collaborative leadership.

Several important lessons emerged from this experience. First, sustaining long-term collaboration requires a balance between standardization and flexibility. While national curriculum guidelines were essential, the process allowed room for contextual adaptation at the university level. Second, maintaining a consistent team across different stages of development provided continuity and institutional memory, which proved invaluable. Third, integrating indigenous knowledge with international expertise not only preserved cultural relevance but also enriched the curriculum as a whole. For example, when training students to intervene in domestic violence cases, particularly when the victim is female, educators emphasize the application of established social work ethics and principles. Although the interventions prioritize the survivor's safety and dignity, students should avoid approaches that isolate her from her family or community. Even when empowering her, it will be within the family system, with an emphasis on protecting family reputation and honor.

At the outset, when Jordanian academics assessed the need to develop the social work curriculum, they reviewed the global standards and compared them with the needs of local practice, following those global standards.

Drawing on another example of gender-based violence (GBV) from cultural and religious perspectives illustrates the alliance with indigenous practices. For instance, in cases where a girl becomes pregnant as a result of rape, the response focuses on a strength-based approach within a collective cultural framework rather than an individualized perspective.

The girl is placed in a protective and highly confidential shelter. After the child is born, the government assumes responsibility for the child's care. In Jordan, adoption is

not legally practiced; instead, children may be placed in institutional care or foster families. Students are, therefore, taught about foster care regulations and parenting skills within this legal and cultural context to enable them to intervene with the girl or foster families.

Curriculum for field training is designed in response to these realities and continues to be developed to ensure that students' practice aligns with local community needs. Training is largely based on institutional work and the specific nature of local social problems. Students are prepared academically and then apply their knowledge during fieldwork, particularly when working with local communities. Thus, the development and preparation of field training programs are fundamentally grounded in local needs and institutional frameworks. Supervision and assessment processes are also structured according to the characteristics of the local community and the institutions involved. Interventions are carefully designed to remain culturally sensitive, recognizing that certain forms of intervention may not be appropriate within the local cultural and religious context.

The collaborative development of Jordan's national social work curriculum stands as a testament to what can be achieved when local leadership, international partnership, and shared vision converge. It fostered a strong sense of institutional ownership, built capacity across universities, and created a platform for continuous improvement. The process was more than just a curriculum reform—it was a transformative experience that strengthened professional identity, deepened academic cooperation, and laid the groundwork for future curriculum innovation. The outcome is a curriculum that is not only nationally standardized but also culturally grounded and globally informed.

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Abbreviations

The following abbreviations are used in this manuscript:

AQACHEI	The Accreditation and Quality Assurance Commission for Higher Education Institutions
JASW	The Jordanian Association of Social Work
IASSW	International Association of Schools of Social Work
IFSW	International Federation of Social Workers
MoSD	Ministry of Social Development
MoHE	Ministry of Higher Education and Scientific Research
NI-CO	Northern Ireland Cooperation Overseas
UNHCR	United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees

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